

Maharaj succumbed to the pressure and suspended Yagnapurushdas's education.

Despite the uproar, Viharilalji Maharaj never lost confidence in Yagnapurushdas. In response to the Rajkot incident, he told Yagnapurushdas to accompany him to various villages around Gujarat. In Umreth, Viharilalji Maharaj sat Yagnapurushdas on the stage and encouraged him to speak freely about Maharaj's supremacy and Akshar-Purushottam *upasana*. The same arrangements were made in Khambhat and Bhavnagar.

Acharya regularly fulfilled Yagnapurushdas's requests. Despite opposition, he invited Bhagatji Maharaj to Gadhada for the Jal-jhilani festival since it was the wish of Yagnapurushdas. For Bhagatji Maharaj's grand reception in Junagadh, Viharilalji Maharaj acknowledged Yagnapurushdas's request to warn adversaries against plotting to ruin the

festival. The Acharya wrote a letter, which was read out loud in the public assembly. The Acharya may have had to postpone Yagnapurushdas' studies, but under his protective eye, he allowed him to continue his mission.

Even though he did not live to see the height of Yagnapurushdas's achievements, over the twenty years they were in contact, Yagnapurushdas eased the Acharya's worries about his legacy for the Sampradaya and earned his faith. When put in perspective, perhaps not having a son of his own allowed Viharilalji Maharaj to focus his attention on nurturing Yagnapurushdas. The Acharya's adopted son had full faith in the Akshar-Purushottam doctrine. Thus, the Acharya could rest knowing that Yagnapurushdas, who had captivated him even as a young boy, would be the true heir and guardian of Maharaj's eternal wisdom. ♦

Nirgundas Swami

Nirgundas Swami surrendered his genius, personality and standing at the feet of Shastriji Maharaj, who he humbly served until his last breath.



It was 4:00 a.m. A peaceful darkness had engulfed Vadodara mandir. But as the pujari made his way to wake up Thakorji, he heard faint sounds coming from the mandir's

pradakshina. There, he was astounded to see that Shastriji Maharaj was still talking to the devotee he had been with since 4:00 p.m. the previous day. Shastriji Maharaj had stayed up all night, explaining to this devotee the glory of Akshar-Purushottam and Bhagatji Maharaj.

The devotee was Jethabhai, a bright young engineering student at Vadodara's Kalabhuvan University. In 1894, Jethabhai had met Bhagatji Maharaj and to honour Bhagatji's wish, he later became a *parshad* and served under Acharya Viharilalji Maharaj, eventually becoming the Kothari of Mumbai mandir.

Jethabhai held a lot of influence in the Sampradaya because he was an expert administrator who was highly educated. In fact, he was one of the Sampradaya's few English speakers at the time. Moreover, he had an uncompromising personality.

But Jethabhai soon learned that Shastriji

Maharaj was so much more than him in every way. Not only was Shastriji Maharaj talented, but he was an ideal sadhu and the only person who could grant him *moksha*. The two were relative equals in terms of age and status in the Sampradaya, yet Jethabhai was inspired to set aside his genius, personality and standing for Shastriji Maharaj, in whose presence he felt forever humbled.

After Bhagatji Maharaj passed away, Jethabhai accepted Shastriji Maharaj as his guru. Jethabhai often described the relationship he had developed with Shastriji Maharaj by this time. Referring to his own resolute nature, he writes, “No one had the guts to tell me to wear saffron [to become a sadhu]. But Shastriji Maharaj did. He told me that my knowledge and working skills would shine more in saffron than in white. These words touched me and I became a sadhu.”

In 1907, about six months after Shastriji Maharaj left Vartal, Jethabhai was initiated as a sadhu and given the name, Nirgundas Swami. Shastriji Maharaj had convinced him, with little more than a hint, to sacrifice personal ambition for a greater cause.

After joining Shastriji Maharaj in Bochasan, Nirgundas Swami poured his soul into spreading the Akshar-Purushottam *upasana* and Shastriji Maharaj’s glory. He underwent extraordinary hardships for Satsang, travelling to villages to meet devotees, discoursing and writing letters that sometimes were over a hundred pages long. Shastriji Maharaj often credited him with almost 90 percent of our Satsang’s growth.

Despite this praise, Nirgundas Swami remained Shastriji Maharaj’s humble servant, forever seeing him as divine no matter what tests he put him through.

A passionate speaker, Nirgun Swami often did *parayans*. As is tradition, devotees gifted him with dhotis at the conclusion of his *parayans*. He would redirect these gifts to Shastriji Maharaj. Once, when Nirgundas Swami really needed new dhotis, Shastriji Maharaj refused to give him a pair and instead gave them to a sannyasi who had

wandered into the mandir.

“Why did you say no to me when you gave them to that sannyasi?” Nirgun Swami asked.

“He has no one to look out for him, where as you do,” Shastriji Maharaj explained.

The clothes had come to the mandir through Nirgundas Swami’s efforts, yet Shastriji Maharaj refused to give them to him. Nirgun Swami, however, saw no fault in Shastriji Maharaj and honoured his wish.

In a letter to Nanda Saheb, on 28 July 1949, Nirgundas Swami proclaims, “Shastriji Maharaj was never influenced by anyone and was able to control such free-willed people as me.”

In his later years, Nirgundas Swami once asked the Sarangpur Mandir *kothari* to install a urinal near his room for convenience. When Shastriji Maharaj found out, he vetoed Nirgundas Swami’s request. Nirgundas Swami tried to reason with him, but Shastriji Maharaj replied, “Whatever the case is, we are not going to make one.”

Shastriji Maharaj denied Nirgundas Swami’s request, but again, Nirgundas Swami did not say a word and instead, he simply bowed to Shastriji Maharaj’s wish.

Nirgundas Swami accepted Shastriji Maharaj’s decision. But he also enjoyed a special working relationship with Shastriji Maharaj. When decisions regarding the Sanstha were being made, they would often have differences of opinion. This did not reflect internal conflict, but, rather, their love for the Sanstha and a desire to arrive at the best possible solution. Eventually, their discussions would always end with Nirgundas Swami following Shastriji Maharaj’s wish.

In 1936, the trustees of Vartal filed a case against BAPS. After three years of court hearings the judgement went against BAPS. Sometime thereafter, Shastriji Maharaj was in Bhavnagar at the home of a devotee named Chimanbhai. There, Nirgundas Swami suggested to Shastriji Maharaj that they should file an appeal. Shastriji Maharaj told Nirgun Swami that he would consider it with Manganbhai, the Sanstha’s secretary.

“What does Magan know?” Nirgundas Swami heatedly replied. “There is no need to ask him. It is due to him that we lost the case!”

But Shastriji Maharaj calmly told him that if he did not like his decision, he was free to leave. Nirgundas Swami took up the offer. But a devotee named Jayantibhai urged him to at least take lunch before going. Nirgundas Swami complied. He then went upstairs and began the morning discourse. Anyone who had witnessed his exchange with Shastriji Maharaj, however, would have been astonished to hear his *katha*. In it, he freely described Shastriji Maharaj’s glory and greatness like never before, as if the earlier argument had never happened.

He always saw his interactions with Shastriji Maharaj as being sacred events in his life. In a letter to a devotee named Harshadbhai Dave, he once wrote, “All of these incidents are divine, and by recalling them, sins are burnt to ash. Everyone can see that there is no end to Shastriji Maharaj’s supremacy and greatness.”

Often it seemed as though Shastriji Maharaj disregarded Nirgundas Swami. In reality, he had great affection for him and an overwhelming appreciation for his contributions to the Sanstha. On 13 September 1943, he wrote in a letter to Nirgundas Swami, “When I am away from you, I think of you constantly, because you and Yogiji Maharaj rank first as leaders of the Gunatit mandal. And you look after everyone through your letters and through the physical hardships you undergo. Shriji-Swami and Bhagatji Maharaj will be very pleased upon you.”

Nirgundas Swami was just one of the many powerful and talented administrators who left Vartal to dedicate their lives to Shastriji Maharaj. He was one of the many who saw that Shastriji Maharaj was ideal in every way, and that he alone held the power to grant. What was special about Nirgundas Swami was that he held this regard for someone who was like his best friend. ♦

Narayanswarupdasji

Narayanswarupdasji, later known as Pramukh Swami Maharaj, saw Shastriji Maharaj as his mother, father and more.



Shastriji Maharaj gave Swamishri this experience of being ‘all-in-one’ – a mother, father, and so much more. Shastriji Maharaj was his everything. For Swamishri, Shastriji Maharaj epitomized the famous *shloka*:

त्वमेव माता च पिता त्वमेव त्वमेव बन्धुश्च सखा त्वमेव ।
त्वमेव विद्या द्रविणं त्वमेव त्वमेव सर्वं मम देव देव ॥
Tvameva mātā cha pitā tvameva
tvameva bandhuscha sakhā tvameva ।
Tvameva vidya dravinam tvameva
tvameva sarvam mama deva deva ॥

God! You are my true mother, father and friend. You are my true knowledge and wealth. You alone are my everything.